

Military files: DARPA / ARPANET as PSYOP

1.1. Memo — 1969: "NETWORKED PSYCHOLOGICAL OPERATIONS"

UNITED STATES DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE
ADVANCED RESEARCH PROJECTS AGENCY (ARPA)
WASHINGTON, D.C. 20301

Classification: TOP SECRET // NOFORN

Date: 29 OCT 1969

From: Office of Behavioral Systems, ARPA

To: Director, Defense Research & Engineering (DDR&E)

Subject: ARPANET — Expanded Behavioral Applications

1. As of this date, the ARPANET experimental packet-switched network has successfully linked multiple research nodes funded by the Department of Defense, creating a resilient communications grid not dependent on any single physical line.

2. Current public justification frames ARPANET as a means of resource sharing between university and military computers, facilitating collaboration and cost efficiency.

3. Internal assessments indicate an additional, underexplored function: the **large-scale modulation of civilian cognition and affect**, via continuous exposure to curated information environments.

4. By routing educational, journalistic, and entertainment content through a single, monitorable network, we can:

- Shape perceived consensus regarding economic and geopolitical realities.

- Encourage *self-pacification* by directing unrest into symbolic, non-physical channels (letters, messages, "discussion lists").

- Generate datasets on opinion formation and susceptibility to suggestion at population scale.

5. We recommend initiating a **PSYNET** subprogram under ARPANET appropriations, with the following preliminary goals:

- Develop protocols for embedding "model civilians" within network traffic—agents whose primary function is to **appear credulous, impulsive, and misinformed**, encouraging self-comparisons that enhance users' sense of personal competence.

- Test whether exposure to such "dummies" correlates with reduced motivation to seek further knowledge, and with increased attribution of systemic failures to "stupid masses" rather than to institutional structures.

6. Long-term objective: create a **self-stabilising information environment** in which citizens believe themselves unusually rational and well-informed, and therefore do not perceive a need for structural change.

[PAGE 2 OF 5 – MISSING FROM ARCHIVE]

7. Preliminary ethical review has been deferred on grounds of national security. See attached note from Psychological Warfare Division (PWD) recommending classification of PSYNET findings for a minimum of 75 years.

Signature

/s/ [REDACTED]

Program Manager, Behavioral Systems, ARPA

1.2. Memo – 1977: “PUBLIC INTERFACE & DUMMY PROFILES”

DEFENSE ADVANCED RESEARCH PROJECTS AGENCY (DARPA)

INFORMATION PROCESSING TECHNIQUES OFFICE

Classification: SECRET

Date: 12 MAY 1977

From: PSYNET Working Group

To: Director, DARPA

Subject: **CIVILIAN-FACING NETWORK SERVICES & BEHAVIORAL NORMALISATION**

1. As the ARPANET transitions toward broader non-military use, civilian universities and contractors request access for mail, news, and experimental “bulletin-board” services.
2. PSYNET Working Group assesses that this transition presents an opportunity to **externalise** earlier laboratory simulations of “dummy profiles” into an uncontrolled environment.
3. Recommended measures:
 - Seed user-visible channels with accounts that:
 - Ask naïve questions in exaggerated forms.
 - Express incoherent political opinions that align outrage with personal grievance rather than systemic analysis.
 - Rapidly adopt and abandon shallow “causes” without sustained engagement.
 - Ensure these profiles **occasionally echo classified talking points in distorted form**, so that authentic leaks can be dismissed as “conspiracy theories” when they resemble dummy discourse.
4. Hypothesis: exposure to these profiles will:
 - Enhance users’ perception of themselves as comparatively lucid and informed.
 - Displace structural anger into contempt for “idiots” and “sheep,” fragmenting solidarity.
 - Encourage **narrative outsourcing**: users assume “if these are my peers, I must already be above average,” and cease critical study.

5. Technical note: initial dummy profiles will be human-operated; however, progress in pattern-recognition and conversational routines suggests automation at scale may be feasible within two decades.

[SECTION 5.1-5.4 REDACTED - SEE FILE 4857-B]

Signature

/s/ [REDACTED]. [REDACTED]

Chair, PSYNET Working Group

1.3. Memo - 1983: "FROM NETWORK TO 'INTERNET'"

DEFENSE ADVANCED RESEARCH PROJECTS AGENCY

STRATEGIC TECHNOLOGIES OFFICE

Classification: TOP SECRET // EYES ONLY

Date: 03 MAR 1983

From: Special Task Force 4857

To: National Security Council Liaison

Subject: **CONSOLIDATION OF CIVILIAN NETWORKS UNDER "INTERNET" FRAME**

1. Packet-switching protocols (TCP/IP) have matured sufficiently to consolidate research, military, and emerging commercial networks into a single inter-networked architecture ("Internet").
2. Public rationale will emphasise scientific collaboration, economic growth, and global communication.
3. Internal rationale remains unchanged:
 - **Centralisation of narrative channels** into infrastructure originally designed and funded by DoD.
 - Expansion of PSYNET protocols to all civilian-facing services: email, discussion forums, future interactive media.
4. Task Force 4857 recommends:
 - Establish and fund front organisations to advocate "open networks" while quietly standardising telemetry and identity requirements.
 - Integrate automated agents ("bots") into emerging services to:
 - Reward short, emotional utterances.
 - Derail complex discussion threads with performative outrage and trivial disputes.
 - Normalise **simulation of political participation** via online "revolt" in place of physical assembly.
5. Long-term scenario: a population that believes itself hyper-informed and hyper-active, while being structurally **docile, fragmented, and easily redirected**.

[PAGE 3 OF 3 - PHOTOCOPY DEGRADED - ILLEGIBLE]